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Reflection Paper #1

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Twigs Naturals

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Internship Reflection Paper

First 50 Hours

The first 50 hours in my cybersecurity internship with Twigs Naturals have provided valuable insight into how cybersecurity works in a real organization. My responsibilities have mainly focused on activities related to governance, risk, and compliance (GRC), along with supporting security processes that are designed to implement and monitor policies, access controls, and training requirements. This internship has given me the opportunity to observe how cybersecurity extends beyond technical systems by serving an important role in the business's daily operations.

In my initial hours, I contributed work that relates to a Cloud Membership Management System request for proposal (RFP). This involved reviewing RFP requirements, drafting a high-level system overview in the form of a Product/Project Design Document (PDD), and mapping functional requirements to proposed system modules (in a chart within a separate document). Throughout this process, I learned how security considerations are included early in the planning

and documentation of a new system. This means that instead of focusing only on the implementation of the system, it's also important to focus on gathering and understanding the requirements, defining the project scope, and confirming that the system design aligns with both the organization's needs and security expectations.

A considerable portion of my time has been spent in the eFense vCISO Portal (an enterprise security platform by Blacksmith InfoSec), which Twigs Naturals uses for security awareness training, user access management, and policy compliance. So far, I've helped with managing user invitations, user information corrections, user removals, and tracking policy acknowledgments and security training completions. This has emphasized the importance of access control and removing access for former employees and interns. I've also communicated with users who have not completed their policy acknowledgments or training yet, and monitored their progress as I continue to keep my supervisor informed. Ultimately, this project has demonstrated how cybersecurity involves more than technical controls; it also requires the participation and accountability of all employees and interns.

Another project has required me to coordinate the intake of organizational policies and standard operating procedures (SOPs). This involves confirming where to store them, contacting department leads for documentation, and tracking their responses as I work towards importing these materials into the security platform. This would aim to centralize policies and SOPs in secure storage, since they're effectively security controls that guide the company's business practices across departments. So, while this project is currently ongoing, it has already demonstrated how cybersecurity involves collaboration, as it requires communication between technical staff and other departments.

Overall, the first 50 hours have taught me how cybersecurity works within real-world constraints. Some examples include communicating clearly with non-technical employees and interns, tracking their compliance progress, and balancing cybersecurity requirements with the operational realities of systems like the Cloud Membership Management System. All of these constraints have been important learning experiences, because they require attention to detail, exercising professionalism, and gaining an understanding of how both technical and human factors affect the organization's overall security posture.